

FREQUENTLY ASKED QUESTIONS- PRODUCT MANAGEMENT

General/Behavioral

- Why this role/company?
- Why do you want to work in the tech industry?
- What other technology company do you most admire?
- Who are the competitors we should be most worried about? Who should we worry about that most people would not expect or is non-traditional?
- What are our three biggest challenges, three biggest opportunities?
- Tell me about a time when you...
 - o Accomplished something you are most proud of?
 - o Demonstrated leadership?
 - o Made a mistake/failed at something?
 - o Overcame an obstacle?
 - o Had to solve an ambiguous problem?
 - o Had a difficult manager?
 - o Had to deal with a complex problem?
 - o Had to deal with someone in the team who was not pulling her/his weight?
 - o Had to use data to solve a problem?
 - o Had to solve a problem quickly, without much time for analysis?
 - o Creatively solved a problem?
 - o Worked cross-functionally?
 - o Did something that was beyond your job description?
 - o Where looking back at things you weren't proud of your actions, or you wished you had done things differently?
 - o Took a risk that did pay off? Did not pay off?
 - o Led a team? You were a follower on the team?
 - o Had to sacrifice short-term benefits for long-term gains?
 - o Needed to persuade a team or person, how did you do it? What happened?
 - o Things didn't go as you planned—what did you do?
 - o Had to deliver a hard message/ bad news?

Product

- What is your favorite product of ours (the top three)? Least favorite (top three)?
- Tell me about a particular area of the firm (e.g. Amazon) or component of the web site that you're interested in. Or which (insert firm name) website have you frequented?
 - o What are we doing well in this area, and what could we improve?
 - o Have you compared it to (other company websites) - what is better/different?
 - o How would you go about improving this area?
- Name 3 things that you will do to improve about our company's website?
- What product of the company do you particularly like?
 - o What would you consider to be a weakness of the product?
 - o What would you do as a product manager to correct this?
- Tell me about a product that you like. What would you improve about that product and why?
 - o Let's size the US market for that product - how would you size it?
 - o If you didn't reach your first year metrics, how would you improve it?
- Name a product and detail what you like and dislike about it (Include 3 likes and 3 dislikes).
 - o How would you make it better?
(Tip: Know the product very well - preferably have experience using the product)
- How will you redesign an alarm clock? (In the wackiest, most technologically advanced way)
- What is your favorite technological product?
 - o If you are product manager of your favorite product, how will you design the next version or generation of that product?
 - o What features will go into it and why?
- Redesign a gas pump using currently available technology.

Mini-cases

- Why do you think Amazon lets 3rd party sellers use its platform?
- If you were to expand Amazon, how would you grow? Which countries?
- How would you launch a product for Brazil?
- We want to expand our grocery business outside of Seattle. How would you choose the next city for the service?
- How would you approach launching a marketplace for rare collectibles on Amazon?
- If Mattel tells you can get 10,000 units at 10% discount today only – what do you do?
- Wal-Mart gets Toy Story 3 from the studio for 20% lower than Amazon at \$8 and they sell it to consumers for \$8.80. What should Amazon do?

Mini Cases (Continued)

- Sony doesn't want to sell their products on Amazon.com – what would you tell them?
- The Nintendo Wii page is the 2nd highest traffic page on our site, but only rarely in stock. How would you (1) optimize the customer experience (2) monetize the traffic flow?
- Motorola is offering you a deal to get \$500 tablets for \$400, but you must take 10,000 units. What would you want to consider making a decision?
- Nintendo is releasing a new gaming console; they have traditionally allocated 5% of their units to Amazon. How do we get more than the historical allocation? (Then lots of follow up questions based on your response)
- Explain what would happen if we raised the price of Amazon Prime by \$10
- How would you have priced Amazon Prime before it was launched?
- How would you go about judging the success of a \$5 or \$25 grocery coupon?
- If your manager offered you \$10M revenue or \$10K profit, which would you choose?
- How would you think about pricing of physical books vs. e-books?
- How do you price a Kindle Fire? (Ultimately asking for a specific price)
- How would you predict the demand if we lower the price of a product?
- You need to develop a product feature and need to convince a team that is working on something else to take that feature, how do you go about it?
- You going into a meeting with Nike's CEO. You want to convince him to sell their shoes on Amazon. What information do you need to prepare your pitch? Now give me the pitch
- The floods in Thailand have disrupted operations at a major camera manufacturer. How would you think about (a) managing existing inventory, (b) pricing and (c) securing more inventory
- Following up on the previous question, say the manufacturer has decided to allocate all of its supply to Best Buy in Thailand. What would you think/do?
- Do you think Amazon should have paid display ads on its site? (After responding) Now take the opposite position
- What would you do if you were a PM on Kindle and a technical bug was going to delay launch in time for Christmas?
- What would you do if there were new competitors coming in to challenge Kindle?
- Sales are falling for Kindle, what would you do?
- Marketplace is now in 9 countries and many different pricing (fees) for different products in different countries. How would you go about optimizing pricing?
- For Amazon Marketplace, what kind of data do you think Amazon should give to merchants to help them price their products optimally?

Mini Cases (Continued)

- Amazon is able to gather a lot of data. One example is the rating that buyers can leave for sellers after each purchase on Amazon Marketplace. This buyer feedback is used in three ways : 1) to give future buyers insight about the experience of working with that merchant; 2) to share information about product / sales process defects with merchants; 3) to help Amazon police fraud and identify problematic sellers. Let's say Jeff Bezos walked up to your desk and wanted to know whether we should spend more resources getting buyers to leave feedback for merchants. How would you quantify the marginal benefit of getting a user to leave feedback for a merchant?
- How would you gain market share in the wireless business?
- You are running late on the R&D for a large client due to a feature enhancement, how would you deal with it?
- eBay's customer satisfaction surveys show an increase in unsatisfied customers from 5% in Q1 to 10% in Q2. What possible causes would you investigate and how?
- How would you determine a successful Email blast strategy from eBay
- What are the key metrics around eBay deals of the day? How would you market those deals?

Technical

- What is Ad Sense?
- How will you evaluate a sales contract or revenue sharing contract with another partner on say Ad Sense?
- You want Dell to ship Chrome browser to all their laptops. What will be the details of that contract?
- What is HTML5?
- What are advantages and disadvantages of XML?
- What's the difference between inner and outer join?
- HTML and CSS? SFTP and SSL?
- How does your browser work? (Similar: what is TCP/IP protocol) or what happens between the time you put an address in your browser to the time the page loads completely?
- Tell me how does the World Wide Web work?
- How to send things over network?
- Walk me through how Google search works.
- Explain relational db to a 6 year old.
- How would you prioritize a feature you want to add?
- What if engineers tell you they're full and to add your feature, they need to take out something. What would you do?
- Trade-off question: You are working on two projects for different partners with the same deadline, but realize that with your limited resources/teams you can only finish one of them on time. How do you go about deciding which project you finish?
- You have to choose a technology to implement a solution for a partner. You are given 17 technologies to choose from. How do you prioritize and choose the right technology to work with?

Technical (continued)

- How would you estimate the number of searches on Google per year in your country? (*Note: Usually not looking for a specific number, but more importantly what factors or data would you look for to get the answer*).
- If we were expanding to that country, how would you estimate the number of servers the new local datacenter would need to support the number of searches? (*Note: specific factors / items more important than exact numbers or calculations*).
- What do you think are the AdWords keywords that cost more to advertisers? (i.e. one potential answer is talking about prices being driven by demand - remember AdWords bidding system - and mention one example.) (E.g., one is 'hotel', there are many companies interested like Priceline, Expedia, Kayak, TripAdvisor...).
- How much space do all videos on YouTube take up?
- What Google products do you like? Tell me what are their strengths and weaknesses? What is your favorite technology product?
- We can only service one thousand people who forget their passwords daily (of five thousand employees total); How do we choose who to service? How do we prevent this problem?
- What are the most significant components that make or break a software product?
- How will you explain $O(n)$ complexity to a 6 year old?
- How much information is stored in world databases?

Out-of-the-box

- How long would it take to fly everyone on earth to the moon? (Assuming you have only one spaceship that can make round trips).
- How would you explain the Internet to your grandmother?
- How would you explain a database to a 5 year old?
- How would you decorate your cube w/ \$100?
- You're in the middle of a safari in Africa and encounter an unknown civilization, which has had no contact with the rest of human kind. How do you explain the benefits of product X to them?
- If you were the Google CEO what 3 problems about the firm would keep you awake at night?
- You got 30s elevator pitch to Google CEO for new idea that you want a team to work on. What would your pitch?
- You get a team of 5 Google engineers. What will you work on starting today and why?